

Democracy's Data: Analytics and Insights into American Elections

[84-355] | Fall 2026

Prof. Jonathan Cervas

Updated: August 21, 2026

Professor Jonathan Cervas

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Location: Porter Hall A21A

Time: Tuesday & Thursday 11:00a-12:20p Eastern

Office Hours: Wed 10:30a-12:30p & 1:30p-3:30p, and by appointment (arrange via email)

CMU Academic Calendar

The most up-to-date version of this **syllabus can be found here**: <https://jcervas.github.io/teaching/2026-2027/class-cmu-2026-84-355/readme.html>

Course Relevance: DC: *Perspectives on Justice and Injustice* **Learning Resources:** All resources will be provided via Canvas

Prerequisites: 36-200 Reasoning with Data

August

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
						1
2	3	4	5	6	7	8
9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22
23	24	25	26	27	28	29
30	31					

September

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
		1	2	3	4	5
6	7	8	9	10	11	12
13	14	15	16	17	18	19
20	21	22	23	24	25	26
27	28	29	30			

October

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
				1	2	3
4	5	6	7	8	9	10
11	12	13	14	15	16	17
18	19	20	21	22	23	24
25	26	27	28	29	30	31

November

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
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8	9	10	11	12	13	14
15	16	17	18	19	20	21
22	23	24	25	26	27	28
29	30					

December

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
		1	2	3	4	5
6	7	8	9	10	11	12
13	14	15	16	17	18	19
20	21	22	23	24	25	26
27	28	29	30	31		

in person

remote

no class

25 meetings, Tuesdays and Thursdays. One of them, **Tue, Nov 24**, meets on Zoom rather than in the room. The tinted days are closures — fall break, Democracy Day, Thanksgiving, and the Constitution Day Symposium.

How American elections actually work, taught through the data they produce. Tuesdays we read; Thursdays we put real election data on the screen and work out what it shows — through the 2026 midterms, live.

01 Assessment

The course grade will be a weighted average of the following components:

Category	Percent of Final Grade
Participation & Attendance	23%
Discussion Board	10%
Surveys (3, completion only)	2%
Weekly Data Contributions	10%
Three Tests (10% each)	30%
Data Journalism Project	25%

What each one is:

- **Participation & Attendance** — Being here, prepared, and in the conversation — on both days.
- **Discussion Board** — By Friday night each week, one post about any of the data we talked about: the lab, a classmate's data slide, a figure in the reading. Something that surprised you, something we missed, something you do not understand, or an answer to somebody else's question. **A few sentences to a paragraph** — enough to show you engaged with what we did. One post is full credit.
- **Surveys** — Three short ones: the **Cervas Election Study** in Week 1, a **midterm feedback** survey once you have seen how the course actually runs, and the **course evaluation** at the end. Graded for completion only — there are no right answers, and nothing you say affects any other part of your grade.
- **Weekly Data Contributions** — Find data bearing on the question Tuesday ended with, name the source, and post it as a slide before Thursday. Each week two slides are drawn at random and worked through in class, and nobody presents the data they found themselves — expect your own data to come up once or twice all term. The slide is marked complete or incomplete each week. At the end of term you hand in a **newsletter**: every piece of data you found, each with a short write-up. **Build it as you go** — it is a paragraph a week, and an evening's work if you leave it all to December.

- **Three Tests** — In class, on paper, and **on the textbook only**. Test 1 on **Thu, Oct 8** (Sides et al., Chapters 1–5), Test 2 on **Tue, Nov 10** (Chapters 6–9), Test 3 on **Thu, Dec 3** (Chapters 10–13). We read the book straight through in its own order, so each test is a block of consecutive chapters: each covers the chapters read since the last one, **none is cumulative**, and every chapter appears on exactly one test. There is no final exam.
- **Data Journalism Project** — A data-driven news story about a trend or issue in electoral processes. Runs in three parts — draft, peer review, final — and **most of the marks are on the first two**. It is the only substantial piece of writing this term.

02 Due Dates

Assignment	Due
Data slide	before each Thursday
Surveys (3)	Wed, Aug 26 (Cervas Election Study), Fri, Oct 23 (midterm feedback), final week (course evaluation)
Discussion board post	Friday, 11:59 p.m. , each week
Data Session 4 board post (no Thursday session)	Tue, Sep 22 — no session to follow that week, so you get the weekend
Week 14 board post (Thanksgiving)	Mon, Nov 30 — Tuesday is on Zoom, and there is no Thursday
Test 1 — Ch. 1–5	Thu, Oct 8 , in class
Data journalism: pitch	Tue, Oct 20 , in class
Test 2 — Ch. 6–9	Tue, Nov 10 , in class
Data journalism: draft	Thu, Nov 19 — the last session before the break
Data journalism: peer reviews (two)	Tue, Dec 1
Test 3 — Ch. 10–13	Thu, Dec 3 , in class
Data newsletter	Tue, Dec 8
Data journalism: final	Fri, Dec 11 — after the last session

There is no final exam.

03 The Essentials

- **Required text:** Sides, Shaw, Grossmann & Lipsitz, *Campaigns and Elections* (W. W. Norton). Everything else is posted on Canvas — there is nothing else to buy.
- **No coding, and nothing to install.** Every lab arrives as a prepared data brief with the results already in front of you; what you do is work out what they show.
- **Tests are on the textbook only** — in class, on paper.

- **Due Wed, Aug 26, 11:59 p.m.:** the Cervas Election Study — link in **Canvas, under Assignments**; screenshot the confirmation screen for credit. It is the first thing due, and Thursday's session uses it.

04 The Full Syllabus

The session-by-session schedule, every reading and lab, assignment details, and all policies:

<https://jcervas.github.io/teaching/2026-2027/class-cmu-2026-84-355/readme.html>